

babu patrons; hangers-on and sycophants, all of them so richly recompensed that before they get down to any actual work, 85 paise is skimmed off every rupee on the average merely to install and keep in place the delivery mechanism. The schemes, in other words, exist for themselves, little bureaucratic empires so incestuously designed that the recipient has no participation in, and less knowledge over the very building blocks of his own life.

The bureaucracy assumes, from the cabinet secretary down to the meanest patwari, that because they are better educated and more

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regularly paid than those they "serve", there is no need to involve the benighted in planning or implementation. Moreover, the self-image of the bureaucracy is that they are not only more efficient but also more honest than politicians, especially low-level politicians. Notwithstanding constitutional arrangements that have been on our statute books for 15 years, there is virtually no discussion on the floor of our legislatures or in government or in the media of how to secure a manifold increase in outcomes without increasing even a paisa of the outlay. State legislators, in particular, block every attempt at genuine empowerment through the effective devolution of functions, finances and functionaries fearing a dilution in their powers of patronage. As long as we rely on an alien and transient bureaucracy to dispassionately "deliver" development to the poor, the delivery mechanism will swallow most of the resources on just putting itself com-

fortably in place. It is only if the money directly reaches the treasury accounts of the elected representatives at the grassroots that the institutions of grassroots governance will become directly and immediately responsible to the Gram Sabha, the constitutionally-mandated assembly of all eligible voters in every village panchayat.

The Constitution has obliged our political system to constitute around 2,50,000 institutions of local self-government to which we have elected no less than 32 lakh representatives, of whom an astonishing 12 lakh are women, and an even more astonishing 80,000 are chairpersons, the greatest-ever experiment in democracy without precedent in history or parallel in the world. We have more elected women in office than the rest of the world put together. Yet, little is known to legislatures or the media about this amazing saga of political and social empowerment. The rising middle class has so monopolised media and political space with its own petty concerns as to crowd out almost altogether the politics of poverty.

The lakhs of elected representatives, closer to their electorate than any bureaucracy will ever be and, therefore, necessarily responsible for delivering responsive administration to

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their electorate, are yet to be made part of the democratic discourse or the development process. For the most part, they are spurned or neglected by the higher echelons of our democracy. But I am confident this will eventually change because democracy is, at bottom, a game of numbers and all we need to do is mobilise 32 lakh local government representatives to pit themselves against 5,000 MPs and MLAs to secure ineluctably, irreversibly and irremovably their constitutional right to be the masters of their fate and the captains of their souls.

Hanging on my wall is a poster with Mahatma Gandhi's response, on the eve of Independence, to a question about the "India of your dreams", to which he responded: "I shall work for an India in which the poorest shall feel that it is their country, in whose making they have an effective voice". It is only when that happens that the politics of poverty will really come into its own. ■

“Because the government is a small player in the healthcare delivery, it must encourage the private sector which delivers nearly 70-80 per cent of it.”

DR DEVI SHETTY
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